"I'll protect the Constitution with my life"

As election fever peaks in the country, PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA MODI took time out from his hectic campaign schedule to speak to India Today Group TV news anchors RAHUL KANWAL, SUDHIR CHAUDHARY, ANJANA OM KASHYAP and SWETA SINGH. In a freewheeling conversation at his 7, Lok Kalyan Marg residence in the capital, the PM touched upon a variety of issues, including the challenges he has set for himself, India's place in the world, while also tearing into the Opposition's charges against his government. Edited excerpts:



Q: You started with the slogan of *'char sau paar'* for the NDA and everyone came down heavily on you. Have you revised the target?

You have families, you have children. If your child scores 90 per cent, I am sure you ask him to score 95 per cent next time. If they score 99 per cent, you push them to score 100. From 2019 to 2024, we already had 400 for the NDA and NDA+. It is my duty to push for 400-plus, move forward. Secondly, as far as responsibility is concerned, it is a leader's duty. Today, it is the misfortune of the country that blame is heaped on the innocent and politicians run away to save their skin. Here you have someone who is prepared to take on responsibility, who does not run away, who takes accountability for what he says. Every political party must have leaders willing to take responsibility.

Q: Do you feel this is the most comfortable election for you?

One should never slip into a comfort zone. If it gets comfortable, I will set a challenge for myself. There are more accidents on a straight highway. Accidents are fewer when there are curves in the road. I want to keep my team awake, want them running.

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Q: A new narrative that the Constitution will be changed seems to be picking up.

The question to be asked is who was the first to tinker with the Constitution? Pandit Nehru was. The first amendment he brought to the Constitution was to restrict the freedom of speech. It was against democracy and the Constitution. The second his daughter Indira Gandhi brought about. The court ruled you cannot stay in Parliament, she overturned it. There were protests, so she declared an Emergency